A VIRAL PROBLEM



One viral video is a scandal, but four in quick succession? That's a headache the **BJP** can do without in the states it rules. From local heavy Manoharlal Dhakad's highway antics in Mandsaur, MP, to district president Amar Kashyap's shenanigans at the party office in Gonda, UP, a string of BJP leaders have recently landed in hot water over viral clips showing them in...let's just say, not-so-*sanskari* situations. The high command is not amused, and an unofficial warning has gone out to the leaders in problem states: clean up your act, or else....

Two Strikes



Rajasthan law minister **Joga Ram Patel** is under fire again, this time over his grandchild being booked for alleged cheating during an engineering exam on May 22. The flying squad flagged it, but the exam centre superintendent gave her a pass, which the Opposition is none too pleased about. Patel insists he's open to even a "CBI probe", but this is the law minister's second family-related fracas. Last year, his son had to quit as additional advocate general after the Opposition questioned the propriety of his appointment.

MR RECONCILIATION



New Tamil Nadu BJP president **Nainar Nagendran** is a sharp contrast to predecessor K. Annamalai, for he has openly backed the alliance with the AIADMK (possibly because his roots lie in the 'Two Leaves' party). Indeed, unlike Annamalai, whose lacerating jibes had led to the alliance breakdown earlier, Nagendran has warned the BJP cadre against publicly criticising the AIADMK, even proposing tracking social media posts to ensure they stay in line. With assembly polls due in a year, he knows the party can ill afford any mis-steps.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Misra, Rohit Parihar and Kavitha Muralidharan

SCI-TECH WATCH

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

TRACKING EARTH, INCH BY INCH

WHAT: The NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar (NISAR) satellite, to be placed in a low earth orbit soon, will scan the Earth's surface every six days measuring minute changes down to a centimetre. With each pixel capturing an area about half the size of a tennis court, it will track how quakes, volcano eruptions and landslides occur; measure the advance or retreat of glaciers and ice sheets; and monitor the growth/loss of forests and wetlands.

HOW: NISAR will be the first earth observation satellite with two kinds of radar—an L-band synthetic aperture radar (SAR) from NASA, and the S-band SAR built by the Space Applications Centre in Ahmedabad. The instrument's imaging swath is greater than 240 km, which will allow it to image the entire planet every 12 days. The NISAR mission will run for five years. Estimated to cost $1.5 billion (Rs 12,765 cr.), NISAR will be among the most expensive earth observation satellites.



WHY: To help prepare for natural or man-made disasters. Earth's surface is in constant flux, NISAR will measure changes in three disciplines:

- Ecosystems, involves vegetation, carbon cycle
- Major changes in the Earth's crust
- Cryosphere sciences which pertain to icy regions crucial to climate change studies.

THE COLLABORATION: An equal collaboration between NASA and ISRO, the NISAR mission marks the first time the two agencies have cooperated on hardware development for an earth-observation mission. The mission is currently targeted for a June 2025 launch. The 2,800 kg NISAR satellite will be launched on a GSLV Mk-II rocket from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre at Sriharikota.